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To the Editor-in-Chief and Associate Editors,
IEEE Access

Dear Editors,

I am pleased to submit the manuscript "Evaluating Tool-Using Language Agents: Judge Reliability, Propagation Cascades, and Runtime Mitigation in AgentProp-Bench" for consideration as a **Research Article** in *IEEE Access*.

Automated evaluation of tool-using large language model (LLM) agents is widely assumed to be reliable, yet this assumption is rarely validated against human annotation. This work quantifies that gap and its consequences. Our main findings, each backed by released code and data, are:

- Substring-based judging—the de facto standard in agent benchmarks—agrees with human annotation at only $\kappa = 0.049$ (chance level), whereas a validated three-LLM ensemble reaches $\kappa = 0.432$.
- Under validated evaluation, a parameter-level injection propagates to a wrong final answer with human-calibrated probability ≈ 0.62, and this holds across nine proprietary and three open-weight (Qwen2.5 3B/7B/14B) models run under an identical harness.
- Models vary by more than an order of magnitude in how often they emit a real tool call (5–100%), and several *fabricate* tool use—asserting results they never obtained. This distinguishes genuine robustness from tool-call avoidance and explains why a runtime interceptor helps one model (-23 pp) but not another.

We believe the work fits *IEEE Access* well: it is a technically complete, fully reproducible empirical study with direct implications for how the community evaluates and deploys LLM agents. All 2,000 tasks, >13,000 agent traces, 100 human labels, analysis scripts, and agent source code are publicly released at `https://github.com/bhaskargurram-ai/agenthallu-bench`; every numerical claim in the manuscript is traceable to a specific file.

This manuscript is original, has not been published previously, and is not under consideration at any other venue. The author has no conflicts of interest to declare. Suggested keywords and manuscript type are provided in the submission.

Thank you for your consideration.

Sincerely,
Bhaskar Gurram